

HEALTH PROFESSIONS ADVISING

MEDICAL SCHOOL HANDBOOK

Purpose of This Handbook

Choosing to pursue a career in medicine is an exciting and deeply personal decision. Whether you have dreamed of becoming a physician for years or are just beginning to explore the profession, the path to medical school requires thoughtful academic planning, meaningful experiences, self-reflection, and a commitment to personal and professional growth.

This handbook was developed by Villanova University's Health Professions Advising (HPA) Program to help you navigate that journey. It serves as a comprehensive resource from your first year through the medical school application process, providing practical guidance and evidence-based advising aligned with current admissions practices.

Throughout this handbook, you will find information on:

- Exploring medicine as a career
- Preparing academically for medical school
- Building meaningful clinical, research, leadership, and service experiences
- Understanding the AAMC Premed Competencies
- Preparing for the MCAT and other admissions assessments
- Navigating the medical school application process
- Selecting schools, interviewing, and considering gap years
- Accessing Villanova and national resources

While this handbook is comprehensive, it is not intended to serve as a checklist or guarantee admission to medical school. Every applicant brings a unique combination of experiences, strengths, interests, and goals, and there is no single pathway to becoming a competitive applicant.

Use your undergraduate years to grow intellectually, personally, and professionally while building a strong foundation for medical school. Strong applicants pair solid academics with intentional exploration of the profession, meaningful reflection, resilience, and continued personal and professional growth.

Use this handbook throughout your undergraduate career, revisit sections as your goals evolve, and meet with Health Professions Advising early and often. We look forward to partnering with you as you prepare for a career in medicine.

Connect with Health Professions Advising

Schedule an Appointment in Handshake

Whether you're exploring medicine for the first time or preparing to apply, Health Professions Advising is here to support you.

We encourage students to schedule an appointment early and visit us often throughout their undergraduate journey.

Meet with HPA to discuss:

- Medical school prerequisites and how they fit within your academic plan
- Career exploration
- Clinical, research, leadership, and volunteer experiences
- MCAT planning
- Application strategy and school selection
- Personal statements and interviews
- Gap years and academic enhancement pathways



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Navigating the Handbook

On the following page, you will find a clickable Table of Contents for this handbook.

Use **Ctrl + F** to search for keywords or phrases throughout the handbook.

Page numbers are located in the bottom-right corner of each page.

Purpose of This Handbook	2
Connect with Health Professions Advising	3
Navigating the Handbook	4
Exploring Medicine as a Career	8
Is Medicine Right for Me?	8
What Do Physicians Do?	10
MD or DO? Understanding the Two Pathways to Becoming a Physician	13
? Frequently Asked Questions: Exploring Medicine	17
💡 Helpful Resources: Exploring Medicine	18
Preparing for Medical School	19
Coursework & Prerequisites	19
How Admissions Committees Evaluate Applicants	19
Medical School Prerequisites	20
Additional Recommended Coursework	22
Choosing a Major	25
AP, IB, and Dual Enrollment Credit	25
Balancing Prerequisites and Your Academic Plan	26
? Frequently Asked Questions: Preparing for Medical School	27
💡 Helpful Resources: Preparing for Medical School	28
Building a Competitive Application	29
AAMC Premed Competencies	29
Clinical Experience	32
Shadowing	34
Community Service	34
Leadership	35
Research	35
💡 Helpful Resources: Building a Competitive Application	37
The Medical School Application Process	38
Timeline	38

Applying Later in the Cycle	42
? Frequently Asked Questions: Application Timeline.....	43
💡 Helpful Resources: Application Timeline.....	44
Application Services (AMCAS, AACOMAS, TMDSAS)	45
Overview of Application Services.....	45
Required Materials	45
Primary and Secondary Applications	46
Application Verification.....	46
Application Fees	46
? Frequently Asked Questions: Application Services.....	48
💡 Helpful Resources: Application Services (AMCAS, AACOMAS, TMDSAS)	49
Letters of Recommendation	50
Villanova Health Professions Advising Letter Packet Process	53
? Frequently Asked Questions: Letters of Recommendation	55
Personal Statement and Work & Activities (Experiences)	56
Personal Statement	56
Work & Activities (Experiences)	57
💡 Villanova Career Center – Writing Assistance	58
? Frequently Asked Questions: Personal Statement and Experiences	59
Interviews	60
💡 Interview Coaching & Mock Interviews.....	64
? Frequently Asked Questions: Interviews	65
MCAT and Standardized Testing	66
Retaking the MCAT	71
Additional Standardized Assessments	73
? Frequently Asked Questions: MCAT and Standardized Testing	75
💡 Helpful Resources: MCAT and Standardized Testing	76
Selecting Medical Schools.....	77
💡 Meet with Health Professions Advising	81

 Frequently Asked Questions: Selecting Medical Schools	82
Gap Years and Reapplying	83
Taking a Gap Year	83
Academic Enhancement.....	84
Reapplying to Medical School	85
 Meet with Health Professions Advising	88
 Frequently Asked Questions: Gap Years and Reapplying	89
In Conclusion	90

Exploring Medicine as a Career

Is Medicine Right for Me?

Medicine is a challenging, rewarding, and service-oriented profession centered on improving the health and well-being of individuals and communities. Physicians care for patients across every stage of life, collaborate with multidisciplinary healthcare teams, and commit to lifelong learning as medicine continues to evolve.

There is no single path to becoming a physician. Some students arrive at Villanova knowing medicine is their goal, while others discover an interest through coursework, research, volunteer experiences, clinical exposure, or personal experiences with healthcare.

If you're considering medicine or simply exploring your options, you don't need to have everything figured out today. One of the goals of Health Professions Advising is to help you determine whether medicine is the right fit for your interests, values, and career goals.

While there is no "perfect" future physician, many successful applicants and physicians share several common characteristics.

You may enjoy a career in medicine if you...

- Enjoy science while also appreciating the human side of healthcare.
- Find fulfillment in serving and advocating for others.
- Are curious and enjoy solving complex problems.
- Communicate well and value working as part of a team.
- Are adaptable, resilient, and willing to learn from challenges.
- Value lifelong learning and continuous professional growth.
- Enjoy building meaningful relationships with patients and colleagues.

Remember: Academic ability alone does not determine whether medicine is the right career. Successful physicians combine scientific knowledge with compassion, professionalism, communication, and a genuine commitment to patient care.

Questions to Ask Yourself

As you begin exploring medicine, consider the following questions:

Personal Motivation

- Why am I interested in becoming a physician?
- What experiences have influenced my interest in medicine?
- Am I pursuing medicine because of my own interests and values, or because of external expectations?

Understanding the Profession

- Have I spent time observing physicians or other healthcare professionals?
- Do I understand both the rewards and challenges of practicing medicine?
- Am I interested in caring for patients, even during difficult or emotionally demanding situations?

Personal Strengths

- Do I enjoy working with people from diverse backgrounds?
- Am I comfortable receiving feedback and continuously improving?
- Can I work collaboratively while maintaining professionalism and integrity?

Long-Term Commitment

- Am I prepared for the time and effort required to complete medical school and residency training?
- Do I enjoy learning enough to make education a lifelong part of my career?

Exploring Medicine Before You Commit

You do not need to know with certainty that medicine is right for you before beginning to explore the profession. In fact, one of the primary purposes of pre-health experiences is to help you answer that question.

As you explore medicine, consider opportunities to:

- Shadow physicians in a variety of specialties.
- Gain clinical experience through patient-facing roles.
- Volunteer in your community.
- Participate in research if it aligns with your interests.
- Speak with current medical students, physicians, and healthcare professionals.
- Meet regularly with a Health Professions Advisor to discuss your goals and experiences.

Many students discover that medicine is the perfect fit. Others realize another healthcare profession better aligns with their interests, and that is equally valuable.

Advisor Perspective: Pre-health advising helps students become competitive applicants while developing into thoughtful future healthcare professionals.

As you gain experience, keep asking yourself one important question: *Can I truly see myself becoming a physician?*

What Do Physicians Do?

Physicians are healthcare professionals who diagnose, treat, and help prevent disease and injury. While many people associate physicians with diagnosing illnesses and prescribing medications, their responsibilities extend far beyond direct patient care.

Depending on their specialty and practice setting, physicians may:

- Evaluate patients through medical histories and physical examinations
- Order and interpret laboratory tests and diagnostic imaging
- Develop treatment plans and prescribe medications
- Perform procedures or surgery
- Counsel patients on disease prevention and healthy lifestyles
- Coordinate care with nurses, pharmacists, therapists, and other healthcare professionals
- Educate patients and families about medical conditions
- Participate in research, teaching, advocacy, public health, or healthcare leadership

Medicine is a collaborative profession. Physicians work alongside multidisciplinary healthcare teams to provide high-quality, patient-centered care.

Where Do Physicians Work?

Physicians practice in a wide variety of settings, including:

- Hospitals
- Private practices
- Community health centers
- Academic medical centers
- Veterans Affairs (VA) hospitals
- Urgent care and outpatient clinics
- Rural and underserved communities
- Government agencies
- Public health organizations
- Military healthcare systems
- International and global health organizations
- Pharmaceutical and biotechnology companies
- Medical education and research institutions

Medical Specialties

One of the most exciting aspects of medicine is the tremendous variety of specialties available after medical school.

Primary Care	Medical Specialties	Surgical Specialties	Other Specialties
Family Medicine	Cardiology	General Surgery	Emergency Medicine
Internal Medicine	Gastroenterology	Orthopedic Surgery	Radiology
Pediatrics	Endocrinology	Neurosurgery	Anesthesiology
Obstetrics & Gynecology	Oncology	Plastic Surgery	Pathology
Geriatrics	Pulmonary & Critical Care	Urology	Physical Medicine & Rehabilitation
Preventive Medicine	Infectious Disease	Ophthalmology	Psychiatry
Hospice & Palliative Medicine	Rheumatology	Otolaryngology (ENT)	Dermatology

 **Did You Know?** There are more than *120 recognized medical specialties and subspecialties in the United States*. Most physicians complete residency training after medical school, and many pursue additional fellowship training to specialize further.

Advisor Tip: Many students enter college believing they already know which specialty they want to pursue. While having interests is perfectly normal, it's important to remain open-minded. Medical school and clinical rotations expose students to many specialties they may never have considered. Your interests, and ultimately your career goals, may change significantly as you gain experience.

Beyond Patient Care

Many physicians build careers that extend beyond the clinic or hospital.

Examples include:

- Medical research
- Clinical trials
- Medical education
- Healthcare administration
- Health policy

- Public health
- Global health
- Medical consulting
- Biotechnology and pharmaceutical development
- Medical journalism and communication
- Entrepreneurship and healthcare innovation

Many physicians combine several of these roles throughout their careers.

MD or DO? Understanding the Two Pathways to Becoming a Physician

Students considering medicine often ask whether they should pursue an MD (Doctor of Medicine) or DO (Doctor of Osteopathic Medicine) degree.

The short answer is that *both MD and DO physicians are fully licensed physicians in the United States*. Both complete four years of medical school, pass national licensing examinations, complete residency training, prescribe medications, perform surgery (if appropriately trained), and practice in every medical specialty.

While the educational pathways share many similarities, they also have distinct histories, philosophies, and curricular differences.

Advisor Perspective: We encourage students to learn about both pathways early in their exploration. Applying broadly to programs that align with your interests, values, and career goals often leads to the strongest application strategy. Both MD and DO programs are accredited U.S. medical schools that educate future physicians. *Students should evaluate individual schools based on their curriculum, mission, clinical opportunities, educational philosophy, and personal fit, not solely on the degree awarded.*

MD and DO at a Glance

Feature	MD (Doctor of Medicine)	DO (Doctor of Osteopathic Medicine)
Degree	Doctor of Medicine	Doctor of Osteopathic Medicine
Medical School Length	4 years	4 years
Residency Training	Yes	Yes
Full Medical Licensure	✓	✓
Prescribe Medications	✓	✓
Perform Surgery	✓	✓
Practice in All Specialties	✓	✓
Additional Training	—	Osteopathic Manipulative Medicine (OMM/OMT)

What Makes Osteopathic Medicine Unique?

Osteopathic medicine was founded in the late 1800s by Andrew Taylor Still, who believed that healthcare should emphasize prevention, the body's ability to heal, and treating the whole person, not simply the disease.

Today, osteopathic medical education continues to emphasize:

- Whole-person (holistic) patient care
- Preventive medicine and wellness
- The relationship between structure and function within the body
- Patient-centered communication
- [Osteopathic Manipulative Medicine \(OMM\)](#), a hands-on diagnostic and treatment approach taught in addition to the standard medical curriculum

All DO students receive training in OMM, although individual physicians vary in how much they incorporate it into practice.

Are MD and DO Physicians Viewed Differently?

Historically, there were significant differences between the two professions. Today, those differences have narrowed considerably.

Since 2020, graduate medical education for MD and DO physicians has operated under a single ACGME accreditation system, allowing graduates of both pathways to apply to ACGME-accredited residency programs. Both degrees lead to full physician licensure and allow graduates to practice independently throughout the United States.

However, students should also be aware that some misconceptions about osteopathic medicine still exist among the general public, and occasionally within parts of the medical community. Many patients are unfamiliar with the DO degree simply because they have never encountered one.

? Should I Apply to MD Programs, DO Programs, or Both?

There is no universal answer. Some students apply only to MD programs. Some apply only to DO programs. Many applicants choose to apply to both.

Your application strategy should be based on factors such as:

- Academic preparation
- Clinical experiences
- Mission fit
- Geographic preferences
- Career interests
- Competitiveness as an applicant

Health Professions Advising can help you develop an individualized school list (See “Selecting Medical Schools”) based on your goals and experiences.

Advisor Tip #1: Students occasionally ask whether they should pursue an MD or DO degree before they have gained meaningful clinical exposure. At this stage, the more important question is often: "Do I want to become a physician?"

As you gain experience through shadowing, clinical work, and conversations with physicians from both backgrounds, you'll develop a better understanding of which educational philosophy and learning environment best align with your goals.

Advisor Tip #2: Some DO schools recommend or require applicants to shadow a DO physician and/or submit a letter from a DO physician. Always verify the requirements of individual programs.

Common Misconceptions

"DOs aren't real doctors." ❌

False.

DO physicians are fully licensed physicians who complete four years of medical school, residency training, and, if desired, fellowship training. They diagnose illness, prescribe medications, perform surgery, deliver babies, and practice across every area of medicine.

"DO physicians can only become primary care doctors." ❌

False.

While many DO graduates choose careers in primary care, they also successfully match into highly competitive specialties and subspecialties each year. Career opportunities depend on many factors, including residency performance, board scores, research, mentorship, career goals, and degree pathway.

"MD programs are always better than DO programs." ❌

False.

Medical schools differ widely in their missions, curricula, research opportunities, patient populations, class sizes, and educational philosophies. A more useful approach is to consider which individual schools best align with your goals, interests, and values.

"If I apply to DO schools, medical schools will think I'm less competitive." ❌

False.

Applying to both MD and DO programs is a common strategy for many applicants. Medical schools understand that applicants are seeking an educational environment that best fits their goals while maximizing their opportunities for admission.

? Frequently Asked Questions: Exploring Medicine

Do I need to know what specialty I want before applying to medical school?

No. Students choose a specialty during or after medical school, following exposure to different fields through clinical rotations and mentorship.

Can physicians combine patient care with research or teaching?

Absolutely. Many physicians divide their careers among clinical practice, research, education, administration, public health, or leadership.

Helpful Resources: Exploring Medicine

- [AAMC Careers in Medicine](#): Explore specialties, career planning, and physician profiles
- [AAMC Specialty Perspectives](#): Hear about different specialties from the physicians themselves
- [ABMS Specialties and Subspecialties](#)
- [Occupational Outlook Handbook – Physicians and Surgeons \(U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics\)](#)
- [American Association of Colleges of Osteopathic Medicine \(AACOM\)](#)
- [Choose DO Explorer](#) (DO Schools Only)
- [Association of American Medical Colleges \(AAMC\)](#)
- [Medical School Admission Requirements \(MSAR\)](#) (MD Schools Only)
- [AAMC Medical Career Paths](#)

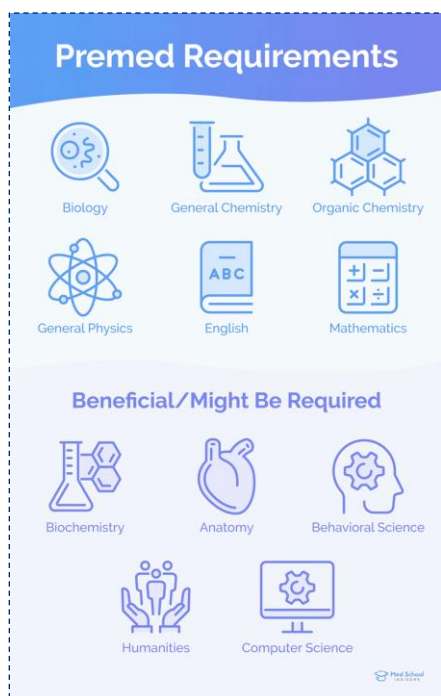
Preparing for Medical School

Coursework & Prerequisites

How Admissions Committees Evaluate Applicants

Your GPA tells only part of the story. Medical schools evaluate multiple aspects of your academic record to determine whether you are prepared for the rigors of medical school. Admissions committees consider your performance over time, the strength of your science foundation, academic trends, and the broader context of your undergraduate education.

Academic Factor	Why It Matters
Overall GPA	Demonstrates consistent academic achievement across all coursework.
Science GPA	Reflects readiness for the biomedical sciences taught in medical school.
Prerequisite Coursework	Shows mastery of the foundational sciences required for medical education.
Upper-Level Science Courses	Provides additional evidence of academic preparedness.
Academic Trends	Demonstrates growth, resilience, and continued development over time.



There is no universal “pre-med” major or set of prerequisite courses required by every medical school. While many schools share similar requirements, coursework expectations and AP credit policies vary by institution. HPA can help you understand medical school prerequisite requirements and admissions expectations, while your Faculty Advisor remains your primary resource for course selection, sequencing, and degree requirements.

Medical School Prerequisites

The subjects below represent common prerequisites and recommended coursework across U.S. medical schools. Requirements vary by institution, so students should verify the policies of the schools they intend to apply to. Use this information as a guide to medical school admissions requirements. Work with your Faculty Advisor to determine how prerequisite coursework fits within your Villanova degree requirements and course sequence.

Subject	Common Villanova Course(s)	Note
Biology	- BIO 2105 & BIO 2106	2 Semesters w/ Labs Some schools may require or strongly prefer additional biology coursework. While AP Biology credit may satisfy introductory biology requirements at some medical schools, students should plan to complete at least two college-level biology courses with laboratories to meet the expectations of the broadest range of medical schools.
General Chemistry	- CHM 1151 & CHM 1103 AND - CHM 1152 & CHM 1104	2 Semesters w/ Labs
Organic Chemistry	- CHM 2211 & CHM 2201 AND - CHM 2212 & CHM 2202	2 Semesters w/ Labs
Physics	- PHY 1100 & PHY 1101 AND - PHY 1102 & PHY 1103 OR - PHY 2410 & PHY 2411 AND - PHY 2412 & PHY 2413	2 Semesters w/ Labs At least one semester of college-level calculus is required to take introductory physics at Villanova.
English / Writing	- ACS 1000 - ACS 1001 - ENG 1975	2 Semesters Most medical schools require one year of English or writing-intensive coursework. ACS 1000/1001 may satisfy these requirements at some institutions, and CLAS students also complete ENG 1975 as part of their degree requirements. Students outside CLAS may need additional English or writing-intensive coursework to meet the expectations of a broader range of medical schools. Students

		should work with their Faculty Advisor to identify appropriate coursework within their academic program and consult HPA regarding medical school requirements.
Statistics	- STAT 1230 - STAT 1250 - STAT 1313 - CSC 2300 - PSY 2000	3 Credits May be a STAT course or a course within an alternate discipline such as psychology (PSY 2000). Course selection should be coordinated with the student's Faculty Advisor, as not all statistics courses satisfy requirements for every Villanova major. STAT 1230 and STAT 1250, for example, typically do not fulfill statistics requirements for CLAS STEM programs. PSY 2000 may also have limited availability for students outside the Psychology major.
Biochemistry	- CHM 4611 OR - CHM 4621	1 Semester CHM 4611 (Survey Biochemistry) covers a broad range of biochemical concepts, while CHM 4621 (Biochemistry I) explores fewer topics in greater depth. Both courses require Organic Chemistry I & II as prerequisites. CHM 4603 is the laboratory associated with CHM 4621; a biochemistry laboratory is generally not required for medical school admission. Students should work with their Faculty Advisor when selecting a course and consult HPA regarding medical school prerequisite and admissions considerations.
Behavioral/Social Sciences	Varies	1–2 Semesters Many medical schools require or strongly recommend coursework in psychology and/or sociology.

Advisor Tip: Completing the minimum prerequisites does not necessarily prepare you for every medical school or for the MCAT. Additional upper-level science coursework, as well as MCAT preparatory courses, can strengthen your academic preparation depending on your interests and goals.

Additional Recommended Coursework

Beyond the prerequisite courses required for medical school, many students choose to take additional upper-level science coursework during their undergraduate education. These courses can allow you to explore areas of scientific interest, build on concepts introduced in prerequisite courses, and deepen your preparation in subjects relevant to medicine and the MCAT.

There is no prescribed list of upper-level science courses that pre-medical students are expected to complete. The courses that make sense for you will depend on your interests, major and degree requirements, prior coursework, course sequencing, MCAT timeline, prospective medical schools, and overall academic plan.

Your Faculty Advisor is an essential resource for selecting and sequencing coursework within your Villanova curriculum. They can help you identify courses that build on your academic interests, satisfy degree requirements, and fit appropriately within your major.

Health Professions Advising can provide an additional admissions perspective. HPA can help you consider whether particular coursework may be strategically useful based on factors such as:

- Specific medical school prerequisites or recommendations
- MCAT content and preparation
- Your previous academic performance and science preparation
- The timing of your application
- The types of medical schools you are considering
- Whether additional academic work would meaningfully strengthen your application
- How coursework fits alongside other priorities such as clinical experience, research, service, and MCAT preparation

For some students, additional upper-level science coursework may provide useful evidence of stronger or more recent academic performance. For others, taking additional science courses may have relatively little impact on admissions competitiveness, and time may be better devoted to other areas of preparation.

Examples of Upper-Level Coursework

Course or Subject Area	How It May Contribute to Your Preparation
Genetics	Builds on foundational biology and explores inheritance, gene expression, and mechanisms relevant to human health and disease.
Microbiology	Develops understanding of microorganisms, infectious disease, and host-pathogen interactions.
Human Physiology	Provides deeper study of normal human body function and physiological systems.

Cell Biology	Builds understanding of cellular structures, signaling, regulation, and mechanisms relevant to health and disease.
Human Anatomy	Provides detailed study of human anatomical structures and relationships.
Molecular Biology	Expands understanding of molecular mechanisms underlying gene expression, regulation, and cellular function.
Immunology	Explores immune-system function, host defense, inflammation, and immune-mediated disease.
Neuroscience / Neurobiology	Examines nervous-system structure and function and may complement interests in behavior, cognition, or neurological disease.
Endocrinology	Explores hormonal regulation, signaling, and physiological control systems.
Experimental Design / Advanced Laboratory Coursework	Provides experience with scientific reasoning, research methodology, data interpretation, and experimental problem-solving.
Other Advanced Biological or Biomedical Sciences	Courses may be valuable based on your academic interests, preparation, and professional goals.

This list is intended to provide examples, not a recommended sequence or a list of courses preferred by HPA or medical school admissions committees. You should not select courses solely because you believe a particular course title will make your application more competitive. There is rarely one universally “best” upper-level science course for a pre-medical student. Work with your Faculty Advisor to determine which courses make sense within your academic program, interests, prerequisites, and course sequence. Meet with HPA when you want to consider those choices in the context of medical school requirements, MCAT preparation, academic readiness, or your broader application strategy.

Choosing Courses Strategically

When considering additional coursework, ask yourself:

- Does this course genuinely interest me?
- Does it fit appropriately within my major and degree requirements?
- Have I completed the prerequisites necessary to be successful in the course?
- Does the sequencing make sense within my broader academic plan?
- Will the course strengthen an area that is relevant to my MCAT preparation?
- Is it required or recommended by any medical schools I am seriously considering?

- Would additional upper-level science coursework meaningfully strengthen my academic preparation?
- Is taking another course the best use of my time, or would another area of my medical school preparation benefit more from that time and attention?
- Have I discussed these courses with my Faculty Advisor?

Choosing a Major

You do not need to major in Biology or another natural science to apply to medical school.

Medical schools accept students from a wide variety of academic disciplines, including:

- Biology
- Chemistry
- Biochemistry
- Comprehensive Sciences
- Engineering
- Psychology / Cognitive Behavioral Neuroscience
- Business
- English
- History
- Philosophy
- Economics
- Mathematics
- Computer Science
- Music
- Foreign Languages

Choose a major that genuinely interests you while ensuring you complete the prerequisite coursework required for medical school. Your Faculty Advisor can help you explore your academic options and plan your major and degree requirements. HPA can help you understand how medical school prerequisites and admissions considerations fit within that broader academic plan.

Medical schools value academic excellence, intellectual curiosity, and the diverse perspectives students bring from many different majors.

AP, IB, and Dual Enrollment Credit

Policies regarding Advanced Placement (AP), International Baccalaureate (IB), and dual enrollment coursework vary considerably among medical schools.

Some schools:

- Accept AP credit without additional coursework.
- Accept AP credit if advanced coursework is completed in college.
- Do not accept AP credit toward prerequisite requirements.

If you entered Villanova with AP, IB, or dual enrollment credit, work with your Faculty Advisor to understand how that credit applies to your Villanova degree requirements and course

placement. HPA can help you understand how individual medical schools may treat that coursework when evaluating prerequisite requirements.

Balancing Prerequisites and Your Academic Plan

A strong academic plan should be appropriately challenging while remaining manageable. Work with your Faculty Advisor on course selection, sequencing, and degree requirements, and consult HPA when considering medical school prerequisites, academic readiness, or application timing.

Your goal should be to:

- Complete prerequisite coursework successfully.
- Demonstrate consistent academic achievement.
- Develop strong study habits.
- Leave time for clinical experiences, service, research, leadership, and personal well-being.

Medical schools evaluate applicants based on a [mission-aligned selection and retention model](#). A balanced, thoughtful academic plan is often more beneficial than overloading your schedule at the expense of other meaningful experiences.

? Frequently Asked Questions: Preparing for Medical School

Do I have to major in Biology?

No. You may major in any discipline while completing the prerequisite coursework required by medical schools. However, depending on your major, this may require taking summer courses to complete medical school prerequisites alongside your Villanova major and degree requirements. Work with your Faculty Advisor to plan your degree requirements and course sequence, and consult HPA regarding medical school prerequisites and application planning.

Should I take additional science courses beyond the prerequisites?

It depends. Students interested in research-intensive schools or those seeking additional preparation for medical school often benefit from upper-level science coursework. However, requirements vary, and additional coursework is not always necessary. Your Faculty Advisor can help you determine how additional coursework fits within your academic program. HPA can provide an admissions perspective on whether additional science coursework may strengthen your preparation based on your academic record, intended schools, and application goals.

Will one prerequisite list satisfy every medical school?

No. While many schools have similar expectations, prerequisite requirements differ. Always review the admissions requirements for the schools where you intend to apply.

Can I complete prerequisites after graduation?

Yes. Many successful applicants complete prerequisite coursework during a post-baccalaureate program or after deciding to pursue medicine later in their academic or professional careers.

Helpful Resources: Preparing for Medical School

Medical School Requirements

- [Medical School Admission Requirements \(MSAR\)](#)
Note: MSAR is a subscription resource published by the AAMC.
- [Choose DO Explorer](#)

Prerequisite Planning

- [AAMC Premed Navigator](#)
- [Meet With HPA](#)

Villanova Resources

- [Villanova Undergraduate Catalog](#)
- DegreeWorks: Go to [myNOVA](#). Search for Degree Works and log in with your Villanova username and password. Complete two-factor authentication.
- [Registrar's Office](#)

Building a Competitive Application

Medical schools use a [mission-aligned selection and retention admissions process](#) (formerly "holistic review"), meaning applicants are evaluated on far more than their GPA and MCAT score. While strong academics are essential, admissions committees also consider an applicant's experiences, personal attributes, motivation for medicine, and potential to become an effective physician.

Focus on sustained, meaningful experiences that contribute to your personal and professional growth and demonstrate a genuine commitment to medicine and service.

Competitive applicants build experiences that reflect their interests, values, commitment to the profession, and long-term goals.

AAMC Premed Competencies

The Association of American Medical Colleges (AAMC) refers to these qualities as the [Premed Competencies](#). These competencies develop over time through academics, clinical experiences, research, service, leadership, employment, and everyday interactions.

AAMC Premed Competency	What It Means	Examples of How You Might Develop It
Professional Competencies		
Commitment to Learning and Growth	Reflecting on successes, challenges, and mistakes; seeking feedback; setting goals; and continually working to improve your knowledge and skills.	Coursework, academic improvement, research, mentorship, incorporating feedback, developing new study strategies
Empathy and Compassion	Recognizing and understanding the experiences, feelings, and perspectives of others and responding with sensitivity and a desire to help.	Clinical experiences, hospice volunteering, peer support, community service, caregiving, mentoring
Ethical Responsibility to Self and Others	Acting with honesty and integrity, considering ethical principles when making decisions, and maintaining professional responsibilities even when faced with pressure or competing values.	Research, clinical work, employment, leadership, academic integrity, service organizations
Interpersonal Skills	Recognizing social and behavioral cues, managing your own emotions	Clinical experiences, employment, student organizations, peer

	appropriately, adapting to interactions, and treating others with dignity and respect.	mentoring, customer service, leadership
Oral Communication	Communicating information clearly, listening actively, recognizing communication barriers, and adjusting your approach when needed.	Presentations, tutoring, teaching, clinical experiences, leadership, employment, public speaking
Reliability and Dependability	Taking responsibility for your commitments, fulfilling obligations in a timely manner, and understanding how your actions affect others.	Long-term employment, volunteer commitments, research, leadership positions, team projects
Resilience and Adaptability	Responding constructively to challenges, uncertainty, setbacks, and changing circumstances while recognizing when support or a change in approach is needed.	Balancing academics and activities, overcoming setbacks, adjusting study strategies, adapting to new environments, employment
Self-Awareness	Reflecting on your own assumptions and perspectives, considering alternative viewpoints, and being willing to revise your thinking as you gain new information or insight.	Reflection, mentorship, community engagement, working with people from different backgrounds, study abroad, leadership
Service Orientation	Demonstrating a commitment to contributing to something larger than yourself and responding meaningfully to the needs of communities.	Community service, food banks, tutoring, hospice, crisis support, mentoring, patient advocacy
Teamwork and Collaboration	Working effectively with others toward shared goals, contributing appropriately as both a team member and leader, sharing information, and giving and receiving feedback.	Research teams, healthcare settings, athletics, student organizations, laboratory courses, group projects
Understanding Others	Recognizing how people's experiences and backgrounds influence their perspectives, behaviors, and interactions and showing curiosity and	Community engagement, clinical experiences, service with diverse populations, language learning, study abroad, mentoring

	respect for individual differences.	
Thinking and Reasoning Competencies		
Critical Thinking	Using logic and reasoning to evaluate information, identify strengths and weaknesses in different approaches, and reach well-supported conclusions.	Science coursework, research, case-based learning, clinical experiences, problem-solving activities
Quantitative Reasoning	Using mathematics and quantitative information to describe, analyze, and explain phenomena in the natural world.	Mathematics, chemistry, physics, statistics, data analysis, research
Scientific Inquiry	Using the scientific process to integrate information, solve problems, develop questions and hypotheses, and understand how scientific knowledge is generated and evaluated.	Laboratory research, honors thesis, independent projects, scientific literature, research methods courses
Written Communication	Communicating information and ideas clearly and effectively in writing.	Research papers, laboratory reports, personal statements, application essays, reflective writing, publications
Science Competencies		
Human Behavior	Applying knowledge of psychological, sociocultural, social, and biological factors to understand human health and well-being.	Psychology, sociology, neuroscience, public health, clinical experiences, community engagement
Living Systems	Applying knowledge of the natural sciences to understand and solve problems involving biological systems, from molecules and cells to organs and organisms.	Biology, biochemistry, physiology, genetics, cell biology, microbiology, laboratory research

Advisor Tip: One experience often demonstrates multiple competencies. For example, working as a medical assistant may simultaneously develop service orientation, teamwork and collaboration, interpersonal skills, self-awareness, understanding others, reliability and

dependability, and resilience and adaptability. Use the competencies as a framework for reflecting on your experiences and how they have shaped your growth as a future healthcare professional.

Clinical Experience

What is Clinical Experience?

Clinical experience involves direct exposure to patient care or healthcare settings that allows you to better understand the realities of medicine and the patient experience.

Clinical experiences help you determine whether medicine is the right career for you while demonstrating to admissions committees that your interest in becoming a physician is informed by firsthand exposure.

Examples

- Patient-facing
 - Medical Assistant
 - EMT
 - Certified Nursing Assistant (CNA)
 - Emergency Department Technician
 - Hospice Volunteer
 - Patient Care Technician
 - Scribe
 - Phlebotomist
- Indirect exposure
 - Hospital Volunteer
 - Clinic Volunteer
 - Medical Interpreter
 - Patient Navigator
 - Inpatient Hospitality Volunteer

What counts as "clinical"?

Experience	Clinical?	Patient Contact?
Medical Assistant	✓	High
EMT	✓	High
Scribe	✓	Moderate
Hospice Volunteer	✓	High
Hospital Front Desk	Sometimes	Limited

Clinical Research	Sometimes	Depends on role
Food Pantry Volunteer	✗	None
Basic Science Research Lab	✗	None

How do I find clinical experiences?

- Local hospitals
- Free clinics
- Hospice organizations
- Nursing homes
- Physicians' offices
- Medical scribe companies
- EMT certification
- Villanova career resources
- Networking with physicians you've shadowed

Advisor Tip: Start early. Clinical experience is best accumulated consistently over time rather than trying to earn hundreds of hours immediately before applying.

Exploring a Variety of Clinical Settings

As you prepare for medical school, seek out clinical experiences across a variety of healthcare settings and specialties whenever possible. Doing so will help you better understand the many ways physicians care for patients and allow you to make a more informed decision about whether medicine is the right career for you.

It is also important to recognize that medical students do not specialize immediately. During medical school, all students complete required clinical clerkships (also called clinical rotations) in a broad range of specialties, including areas such as internal medicine, surgery, pediatrics, obstetrics and gynecology, psychiatry, family medicine, and emergency medicine. These experiences provide the foundation for developing well-rounded physicians and help students determine which specialty they may ultimately pursue during residency.

Because every medical student completes these core clinical rotations, you should be prepared to care for patients in a variety of medical settings, including those outside your current interests or comfort zone. For example, a student who plans to pursue psychiatry will still complete rotations in surgery and emergency medicine, just as a student interested in orthopedic surgery will also rotate through pediatrics and psychiatry.

Clinical experiences during college can help you better understand these expectations and prepare for the realities of medical training. **If aspects of patient care make you uncomfortable, such as blood, invasive procedures, or emotionally challenging situations,**

early clinical experience can help you understand those reactions, develop coping strategies, and evaluate your comfort with the realities of medicine.

Shadowing

Shadowing allows students to observe physicians as they care for patients and work within the healthcare system. Unlike clinical experience, shadowing is primarily observational. Its purpose is to help students understand the day-to-day realities of medical practice.

? Should I shadow only MD physicians?

No. Students are encouraged to shadow physicians from a variety of specialties and backgrounds, including both MD and DO physicians.

Shadowing other healthcare professionals, such as physician assistants, nurse practitioners, physical therapists, pharmacists, dentists, and nurses, can also provide valuable insight into the healthcare team and help students better understand different healthcare careers.

However, applicants to medical school should ensure that a significant portion of their shadowing includes physicians.

? How much shadowing is enough?

There is no universal requirement, and every medical school will have different requirements or expectations. Quality matters far more than quantity.

Shadowing across multiple specialties and practice settings, including primary care when possible, often provides a more complete understanding than accumulating hours with only one physician.

Finding Shadowing Opportunities

- Personal physicians
- Alumni ([NovaNetwork](#))
- Faculty mentors
- Family/community connections
- Local hospitals
- Cold calls
- Cold emails (professionally written)

Community Service

Medicine is fundamentally a profession of service. Medical schools value a sustained commitment to helping others because service is central to the physician's role.

Students are encouraged to pursue service opportunities that align with causes they genuinely care about.

Admissions committees can often distinguish between long-term, meaningful engagement and experiences pursued solely to fulfill perceived application requirements.

Examples

- Food insecurity
- Tutoring
- Crisis text line
- Habitat for Humanity
- Homeless shelters
- Special Olympics
- Refugee organizations
- Religious/community organizations

Advisor Tip: Consistency is generally more meaningful than brief involvement in many unrelated organizations.

Leadership

Leadership is not limited to holding a title. Medical schools value applicants who demonstrate initiative, responsibility, collaboration, and the ability to positively influence others.

Leadership may include:

- Executive board positions in student organizations
- Resident assistant
- Orientation leader
- Peer tutor
- Teaching assistant
- Research team leadership
- Employment with supervisory responsibilities
- Starting a student organization
- Organizing campus initiatives

Research

Research is not required for admission to every medical school. It may become more or less important depending on the schools you ultimately apply to.

However, research experience can strengthen an application by demonstrating curiosity, critical thinking, scientific inquiry, and problem-solving skills. It is particularly valuable for students interested in research-intensive institutions or physician-scientist careers.

Research experiences may occur in:

- Basic science laboratories
- Clinical research
- Public health
- Engineering
- Psychology
- Social sciences
- Humanities
- Education

 Students interested in research are encouraged to explore opportunities through **Villanova's Center for Research & Fellowships (CRF)**, which supports undergraduate research, faculty mentorship, funding opportunities, summer research, and nationally competitive fellowships.

Quality vs. Quantity

Admissions committees consider the quality, duration, and impact of your experiences in addition to the number of hours completed. Some schools publish minimum experience requirements, but sustained involvement, reflection, and growth are generally more meaningful than accumulating disconnected activities to reach a target number.

💡 Helpful Resources: Building a Competitive Application

- [Meet With HPA](#)
- [AAMC Premed Competencies Resources](#)
- [AAMC Anatomy of an Applicant](#)
- [Villanova Center for Research & Fellowships \(CRF\)](#)
- [Villanova Career Center](#)
- [Villanova Office of Student Involvement](#)
- [Idealist / VolunteerMatch](#)
- [Handshake Jobs](#)
- [Main Line Health Volunteer Opportunities](#)
- [Hospital of the University of Pennsylvania \(HUP\) Volunteer Opportunities](#)

The Medical School Application Process

Timeline

Applying to medical school is a year-long process that begins well before classes start. Understanding the timeline can help you stay organized, reduce stress, and avoid unnecessary delays.

Most applicants submit their applications approximately 15 months before they expect to begin medical school. For example:

Desired Medical School Start	Application Opens	Ideal Primary Application Submission Timeframe	Begin Medical School
Fall 2028	May 2027	May–July 2027	August 2028

Although exact dates vary slightly from year to year, the overall timeline remains largely the same.

Advisor Tip: It is never too early to begin preparing your application materials. Students who plan ahead often experience less stress and are better positioned to submit a strong application early in the cycle.

Why Timing Matters

Medical school admissions are highly competitive, and many schools use *rolling admissions*.

This means applications are reviewed as they become complete rather than waiting until the application deadline. As interview invitations are extended and seats begin to fill, later applicants may be competing for fewer available interview spots.

Applying early does not guarantee admission, but submitting a complete, high-quality application early in the cycle generally provides the greatest opportunity for consideration.

That said, *applicants should never sacrifice the quality of their application simply to submit earlier*. A thoughtful, polished application submitted in June is typically stronger than a rushed application submitted in May.

Advisor Perspective: Apply early, but only when your application accurately reflects your strongest work.

Before the Application Opens (January–April)

The months leading up to the application opening are an excellent time to prepare.

During this period, students should:

- [Meet with Health Professions Advising.](#)
- Finalize a preliminary school list.
- Begin or revise their personal statement.
 - See section: “Personal Statement”.
- Update their resume or curriculum vitae (CV).
- Request letters of recommendation.
 - See section: “Villanova Health Professions Advising Letter Packet Process”
- Order unofficial transcripts and review coursework for accuracy.
- Continue gaining meaningful clinical, research, leadership, and service experiences.
- Take or finalize plans for the MCAT, if applicable.

Students are also encouraged to familiarize themselves with the application service(s) they will be using (AMCAS, AACOMAS, and/or TMDSAS). See the **Application Services (AMCAS, AACOMAS, TMDSAS)** section.

Application Opens (May)

Most centralized application services open in early May.

At this stage, applicants can begin entering:

- Personal information
- Coursework
- Experiences
- Personal statement
- School selections
- Letters of recommendation assignments

Although the application opens in May, applicants do not need to submit it immediately. Use this time to carefully proofread every section and ensure that your application accurately reflects your experiences and accomplishments.

Submitting Your Primary Application (Late May–July)

For most applicants, submitting the primary application between May and early July is considered an excellent timeline.

Before submitting, confirm that you have:

- Carefully reviewed every section of your application.
- Proofread your personal statement and activities.

- Assigned letters of recommendation.
- Selected your schools thoughtfully.
- Requested official transcripts.
 - Graduating seniors will need to wait until degrees are conferred on their transcript after May 31.

Once submitted, your application enters the verification process.

Application Verification

After submission, your primary application must be verified before it is transmitted to medical schools.

During verification, the application service compares the coursework you entered with your official college transcripts to ensure accuracy.

Verification times vary throughout the application cycle.

Early applicants may be verified relatively quickly, while applications submitted later in the summer may take several weeks to process. Applicants should anticipate an approximate two-week verification period, although a specific timeframe cannot be guaranteed.

Because verification time is outside the applicant's control, early submission can help reduce avoidable delays.

Advisor Tip: Request official transcripts early and enter your coursework carefully. Errors may delay verification and postpone transmission of your application to medical schools.

The Waiting Game

After submitting your primary application, it is common to feel as though nothing is happening. In reality, several important processes are occurring behind the scenes:

- Your application is being verified.
- Medical schools are receiving verified applications.
- Schools are reviewing applications for secondary invitations.
- Letters of recommendation continue arriving.
- MCAT scores may still be pending.

Use this period to prepare for the next stages of the application cycle:

- Continue volunteering or working.
- Gain additional clinical or research experience.
- Prepare for potential interviews.

- Begin drafting responses to common secondary essay prompts.
- Practice self-care and maintain healthy routines.

Secondary Applications (June–September)

After reviewing your primary application, many medical schools will invite applicants to complete secondary applications.

Some schools send secondary applications to nearly every applicant, while others screen applications before extending invitations.

Secondary applications often include:

- School-specific essays
- Additional demographic information
- Institutional questions
- Application fees

Students are generally encouraged to return secondary applications within approximately two weeks, unless otherwise directed by the school.

For more information about primary and secondary applications, see the "Primary and Secondary Applications" section of this handbook.

Interviews (August–March)

Interview invitations may begin arriving as early as late summer and continue throughout the application cycle. Schools vary considerably in their interview schedules.

Applicants should continue checking email regularly, monitor application portals, and respond promptly to interview invitations.

For more information about interview preparation, see the "Interviews" section of this handbook.

Admissions Decisions (October–Summer)

Medical schools release admissions decisions throughout the cycle according to their individual timelines.

Applicants may receive:

- Acceptance offers

- Waitlist decisions
- Rejections
- Requests for additional information

Many applicants receive decisions over several months, and it is common for schools to continue interviewing and making offers well into the spring. Students who are waitlisted may be offered a seat later in the summer if a seat becomes available. Patience is an important part of the process.

Applying Later in the Cycle

Although many medical schools continue accepting applications into the fall or winter, applicants should understand that **application deadlines and competitive timing are not the same thing**.

Many MD and DO programs use rolling admissions, meaning applications are reviewed as they become complete, and interview invitations are extended throughout the application cycle. As the cycle progresses, interview spots and available seats may become more limited.

A later application does not automatically prevent admission, and many students are admitted after applying later in the cycle. Applicants considering a delayed application because of a later MCAT date, pending coursework, additional experiences, or other circumstances should understand how the delay may affect their application strategy.

Advisor Tip: If your application timeline changes for any reason, **schedule an appointment with Health Professions Advising**. We can help you evaluate your individual circumstances, discuss the potential impact on your application, and determine whether applying later this cycle or waiting until the next application cycle may better position you for success.

? Frequently Asked Questions: Application Timeline

What happens if my MCAT score hasn't been released yet?

You may submit your primary application before receiving your MCAT score. Most medical schools will review your application after an official score has been received. Be sure to check with the schools on your list to verify their preferences/requirements and discuss this strategy with Health Professions Advising before moving forward. Additionally, practice test scores can help students and HPA Advisors better understand whether submitting without an MCAT is the appropriate application strategy.

How long does verification take?

Verification times vary depending on the time of year and application volume. Applications submitted early in the cycle are often verified more quickly than those submitted later in the summer.

When should I apply?

Most students apply one year before they plan to begin medical school. Applications for the year you want to start will open in May the year before you intend to enroll. For example, if you plan to begin medical school in Fall 2028, you would typically submit your primary application in May, June, or July 2027. MCAT scores and letters of recommendation may follow separate timelines depending on your application strategy and individual school requirements.

Can I apply before finishing all of my prerequisite courses?

In many cases, yes. Applicants may have coursework "in progress" or planned during their senior year, provided all prerequisites are completed before matriculation. Individual school policies vary.

Do I need to apply only through one application service?

No. Applicants can apply through one, two, or all three application services; however, each application service is for a specific type of school. The next section provides an overview of the major centralized application services.

Helpful Resources: Application Timeline

- [AAMC Applying to Medical School](#)
- [AACOM Applicant Resources](#)
- [Meet With HPA](#)

Application Services (AMCAS, AACOMAS, TMDSAS)

Unlike undergraduate admissions, there is no single application accepted by every U.S. medical school. Instead, applicants submit their applications through one or more centralized application services depending on the schools they plan to apply to.

Each application service collects your academic information, experiences, personal statement, letters of recommendation, and transcripts before transmitting your application to participating medical schools.

Overview of Application Services

Many applicants apply to both MD and DO programs and therefore submit applications through both AMCAS (MD) and AACOMAS (DO).

Students applying to participating medical schools in Texas generally use TMDSAS, even if they are also applying through AMCAS or AACOMAS.

Each application service requires its own application and associated fees.

Application Service	Degree(s)	Used By	Website
AMCAS (American Medical College Application Service)	MD	Most U.S. allopathic medical schools	AMCAS Application
AACOMAS (American Association of Colleges of Osteopathic Medicine Application Service)	DO	Most U.S. osteopathic medical schools	AACOMAS Application
TMDSAS (Texas Medical and Dental Schools Application Services)	MD, DO, DDS, DVM (Texas public schools)	Participating Texas medical, dental, and veterinary schools	TMDSAS Application

Required Materials

Although each application service differs slightly, applicants generally provide:

- Personal information
- Official college transcripts
- Coursework entry
- MCAT scores

- Personal statement
- Work and activities/experiences
- Letters of recommendation
- School selections
- Demographic information
- Institutional actions or legal disclosures (if applicable)

Many schools also require supplemental ("secondary") applications after reviewing the primary application.

Primary and Secondary Applications

Students are often surprised to learn that submitting a primary application is only the beginning of the admissions process.

Primary Application

Your primary application is submitted through AMCAS, AACOMAS, or TMDSAS and contains the core materials listed above. Once verified, your application is transmitted to your selected medical schools.

Secondary Application

Many medical schools send applicants a supplemental (secondary) application after receiving the primary application.

Secondary applications often include:

- School-specific essays
- Questions about your experiences
- Mission fit
- Diversity and inclusion
- Service and leadership
- Institution-specific information

Many schools charge an additional secondary application fee.

Application Verification

Applications must be verified before they are transmitted to schools. See Application Verification in the Application Timeline section for details about the process and timing.

Application Fees

Each application service charges an initial application fee, with additional fees for each school selected.

Applicants should budget for:

- Primary application fees
- Additional school designation fees
- Secondary application fees
- MCAT registration
- CASPer/Duet/PREview assessments (if required)
- Interview expenses (when applicable)

Fee assistance programs are available for eligible applicants through several application services. Students seeking fee assistance through AMCAS, AACOMAS, and/or TMDSAS will need to submit applications for fee assistance to each individual application service and provide income and tax information. Some medical schools may offer fee waivers to eligible applicants upon request. Please contact HPA if you have questions regarding fee assistance.

? Frequently Asked Questions: Application Services

If I apply to both MD and DO schools, do I complete two applications?

Yes. Although much of the information is similar, AMCAS and AACOMAS are separate application services.

Do I have to individually list every single one of my work/volunteer/shadowing/clinical experiences?

Not necessarily. Application services have different limits and formats. For example, AMCAS allows up to 15 entries, so applicants should select the experiences that best represent their preparation and may group related experiences when appropriate.

Do I have to manually input every single course I've taken into the application?

Yes. You must enter each course as it appears on your transcript for application verification.

Can I change my school list after submitting?

Generally, yes. Applicants may add schools after submitting their primary application, although additional fees apply. Policies vary by application service.

Do all schools send secondary applications?

Not necessarily. Many schools send secondary applications to most applicants, while others screen applications before inviting applicants to complete a secondary application.

Can I get a refund if I change my mind about applying to a school after I have submitted through AACOMAS or AMCAS?

Generally, no. HPA stresses the importance of your school list for many reasons, this being one of them. Secondary fees and acceptance deposits are also typically nonrefundable, but this may depend on each individual school's policy.

💡 Helpful Resources: Application Services (AMCAS, AACOMAS, TMDSAS)

- [AMCAS \(AAMC\)](#)
- [AACOMAS \(AACOM\)](#)
- [TMDSAS](#)
- [AAMC Fee Assistance Program](#)
- [AACOMAS Fee Waiver Information](#)

Letters of Recommendation

Letters of recommendation (LORs) provide medical schools with an independent assessment of your academic ability, professionalism, character, and readiness for a career in medicine. Strong letters offer insight into who you are beyond your GPA, MCAT score, and list of experiences.

The best letters come from individuals who know you well and can speak to your strengths through specific examples, not simply those with impressive titles.

Who Should Write My Letters?

Medical schools vary in their letter requirements, but many applicants submit letters from a combination of:

- Science faculty (many schools require 2 science faculty letters)
- Non-science faculty
- Research mentors
- Physicians (when appropriate)
- Employers or supervisors
- Volunteer coordinators

Some institutions require or strongly prefer an institutional letter or letter packet when an applicant's undergraduate institution offers one.

Advisor Tip #1: Always review the letter requirements for the medical schools where you intend to apply. Requirements vary by institution.

Advisor Tip #2: Letters should come from people who know you in a professional, academic, and/or mentorship capacity. *Do not ask for letters of recommendation from personal friends, family, or healthcare providers who cannot speak to your abilities in a professional or academic context.*

What Makes a Strong Letter?

Strong recommendation letters are written by individuals who know you well and can comment on your:

- Academic ability
- Critical thinking and intellectual curiosity
- Communication skills
- Professionalism

- Reliability and work ethic
- Leadership
- Teamwork
- Compassion and interpersonal skills
- Readiness for medical school

Building Relationships with Potential Recommenders

Students should begin developing relationships with faculty and mentors well before applying to medical school.

Consider:

- Attending office hours
- Participating actively in class
- Seeking research opportunities
- Serving as a teaching assistant or peer tutor
- Staying in contact after completing a course
- Asking thoughtful questions and seeking mentorship

Strong letters are built over time.

When Should I Ask?

Plan to request letters at least 2–3 months before you need them, and ideally before the end of the semester if asking a faculty member.

Giving recommenders plenty of time allows them to write thoughtful, detailed letters.

What Should I Provide to My Recommenders?

To help your recommender write a strong letter, consider providing:

- Current resume or CV
- Unofficial transcript
- Personal statement draft (if available)
- Brief statement describing why you are pursuing medicine
- List of schools (optional)
- Summary of experiences since taking their course or working with them
- Submission instructions and deadlines

Providing this information allows recommenders to write more personalized and detailed letters.

Waiving Your Right to View Letters

Applicants are generally encouraged to waive their right to view recommendation letters.

Medical schools often place greater confidence in confidential letters because they are more likely to represent an honest assessment.

Villanova Health Professions Advising Letter Packet Process

Many schools require, or strongly prefer, a letter packet compiled by Health Professions Advising (HPA) when possible. HPA has a process in place to support students applying to dental school, including the collection and submission of letters of recommendation. Students are not required to submit a letter packet through HPA for their applications, but it is strongly recommended.

HPA Letter Packet Interest Form and Application

Step 1: Submit the HPA Letter Packet Interest Form

- The HPA Letter Packet Interest Form will be available in mid-October for students considering applying in the upcoming cycle. The form will be available through [HPA Brightspace](#) and [HPA Career Connections](#).
- For students applying in the **2027–2028 cycle**, the Interest Form is due **Friday, January 15, 2027**.
- Students who do not submit the Interest Form by the January 15 deadline will not be eligible to participate in the HPA letter packet process for the 2027–2028 cycle.

Step 2: Complete the HPA Letter Packet Slate Application

- The HPA Letter Packet Slate Application for the **2027–2028 cycle** will open in Slate on **Tuesday, January 19, 2027**. The application link will be emailed to students who submitted the Interest Form by the deadline.
- Instructions and required forms will be provided within the Slate application.

Step 3: Upload Application Preparation Materials

- Students must upload the following materials to Slate by **Friday, April 2, 2027**:
 - Unofficial transcripts from *all* attended institutions, including Villanova University, community colleges, etc.
 - Polished draft of personal statement
 - Resume/CV
 - Pre-Meeting Questionnaire
- After uploading these materials, students are required to meet with an HPA advisor for an application preparation meeting. **Completion of this meeting is required to receive an HPA letter packet.**

Step 4: Complete Letter Packet Requirements

- HPA will collect individual letters of recommendation and evaluations directly from recommenders. Applicants must provide a **minimum of three and maximum of five letters of recommendation.**
- Before HPA can submit a letter packet, the following must also be completed in Slate:
 - Code Form
 - Authorization of Release
 - Names and contact information of recommenders
 - All required letters of recommendation and evaluations received by HPA
- Required HPA application preparation meeting completed

Step 5: Packet Compilation and Submission

- Letter packet compilation begins in May. HPA will submit the completed packet to the appropriate centralized application service once all requirements have been completed.
- **The Slate application and all remaining letter packet requirements must be completed no later than September 1, 2027.** HPA will not process letter packets for students who have not completed all requirements by this deadline.

2027 HPA Letter Packet Process Important Dates & Deadlines	
Mid-October 2026	HPA Letter Packet Interest Form Available on Brightspace and Career Connections
January 15, 2027	HPA Letter Packet Interest Form Due
January 19, 2027	HPA Letter Packet Slate Application Available
April 2, 2027	Application preparation materials listed in Step 3 due in Slate
March-May 2027	Meet with HPA advisor for application prep meeting
September 1, 2027	Final Letter Packet Completion Deadline

? Frequently Asked Questions: Letters of Recommendation

How many letters do I need?

Requirements vary by school. Many medical schools request 3–5 letters, though some accept additional letters and others have maximum limits. Always verify individual school requirements.

Should I ask a physician for a letter?

It can be helpful, but it is not universally required or recommended. A physician letter is most valuable when the physician knows you well enough to write a detailed recommendation.

Some DO schools recommend or require a letter from a DO physician, while many MD schools do not require a physician letter at all.

Should I ask the professor from the class where I earned the highest grade?

Not automatically. Choose faculty members who know you well and can speak meaningfully about your abilities and character, not simply those whose course you performed well in.

Can I reuse letters if I take a gap year?

Often, yes. Many applicants store letters through services such as Interfolio or Villanova's HPA letter packet process, though some recommenders may wish to update their letters before you apply.

Personal Statement and Work & Activities (Experiences)

Your personal statement and experiences section are among the most important qualitative components of your medical school application. Together, they help admissions committees understand **who you are, what has shaped your interest in medicine, and why you are prepared to pursue a career as a physician.**

While your transcript and MCAT demonstrate academic readiness, your written application provides context, reflection, and insight into your experiences and motivations.

💡 Need help getting started?

Students are encouraged to [meet with John McGranaghan in the Villanova Career Center](#) early in the writing process. Beginning with a rough draft, not a polished essay, often leads to the strongest final personal statement.

Personal Statement

What is the Personal Statement?

The personal statement is your opportunity to explain why you want to become a physician.

An effective personal statement tells a cohesive story about the experiences, values, and moments that led you toward medicine.

Admissions committees want to understand:

- Why medicine?
- What experiences shaped your decision?
- What have you learned through those experiences?
- How have you grown personally and professionally?
- What qualities will you bring to the profession?

What Makes a Strong Personal Statement?

Successful personal statements are:

- Authentic and reflective
- Focused on personal growth
- Organized around a clear narrative
- Supported by meaningful experiences
- Well-written and carefully revised

Common Mistakes

- Simply repeating your resume
- Writing what you think admissions committees want to hear
- Focusing exclusively on childhood stories or a single patient encounter without reflection
- Overusing medical terminology
- Making unsupported claims about your abilities
- Waiting until the application opens to begin writing

Work & Activities (Experiences)

The Experiences section allows applicants to describe many of the activities that have shaped their preparation for medical school.

Examples include:

- Clinical experience
- Physician shadowing
- Community service
- Leadership
- Research
- Employment
- Teaching and tutoring
- Military service
- Athletics
- Artistic pursuits
- Meaningful hobbies and personal interests

Admissions committees want to understand what you did, what you learned, and how the experience influenced your development.

Quality Reflection Matters

Strong activity descriptions include reflection in addition to explaining what you did. Consider discussing:

- What you learned about patient care
- How the experience influenced your understanding of medicine
- Challenges you encountered
- Skills you developed
- Why the experience was meaningful to you

Villanova Career Center – Writing Assistance

Writing a compelling personal statement takes time, multiple revisions, and constructive feedback.

Students are encouraged to begin drafting early and seek input from trusted mentors, advisors, faculty members, and professional writing specialists.

The Villanova Career Center provides individualized support for applicants developing personal statements and application materials.

Students are encouraged to [schedule an appointment with John McGranaghan](#), who works extensively with health professions applicants on developing, refining, and polishing personal statements and experience descriptions through multiple rounds of revision.

The Career Center can also assist students with:

- Brainstorming ideas
- Developing a compelling narrative
- Organization and structure
- Clarity and readability
- Revision strategies
- Professional writing feedback

Health Professions Advising and the Career Center work collaboratively to support applicants throughout the medical school application process.

? Frequently Asked Questions: Personal Statement and Experiences

When should I start writing my personal statement?

Ideally, begin drafting several months before submitting your primary application. Starting early provides ample time for reflection, revision, and feedback.

Should I have multiple people review my essay?

Yes. Seek feedback from individuals who understand the medical school admissions process and can help strengthen your writing while preserving your authentic voice.

Can I write about a personal illness or family experience?

Yes. Personal experiences can provide meaningful context when they genuinely shape your interest in medicine. However, the focus should remain on your *growth, insights, and motivation, rather than the event itself.*

Do medical schools want dramatic stories?

Not necessarily. Many successful personal statements describe ordinary experiences that are thoughtfully reflected upon. Admissions committees value authenticity and insight far more than dramatic narratives. Additionally, if you receive an interview, it is very likely that you will be asked to expand on anything you write in your application, including personal statements and experiences. Be prepared to discuss all aspects of your application in an interview.

Advisor Perspective: A compelling personal statement explains why you want to become a physician, why you are ready to pursue that path now, and how your experiences shaped that decision. Write in your own voice and ground your reflections in specific experiences.

Interviews

Receiving an interview invitation is a significant milestone in the medical school application process. It indicates that the admissions committee believes you have the academic preparation and experiences necessary to be considered for admission.

While interviews can feel intimidating, they are also an opportunity for applicants to learn more about a medical school and determine whether it is a good fit for their goals, values, and learning style.

Interview Formats

There is no single medical school interview format. Each institution designs its interview process to align with its admissions philosophy and mission.

Common interview formats include:

- **Traditional Interviews**

Applicants participate in one or more conversations with faculty members, admissions staff, students, physicians, and/or alumni.

Questions often focus on:

- Motivation for medicine
- Experiences and activities
- Leadership
- Ethical reasoning
- Professionalism
- Communication skills
- School-specific interests

- **Multiple Mini Interviews (MMIs)**

The Multiple Mini Interview (MMI) consists of a series of short interview stations designed to evaluate competencies such as:

- Communication
- Critical thinking
- Ethical decision-making
- Teamwork
- Empathy
- Adaptability

Applicants rotate through several independent scenarios, each with a different interviewer.

- **Group Interviews**

Some schools incorporate group discussions or collaborative activities to observe teamwork,

communication, and professionalism.

- **Hybrid Formats**

Many schools combine multiple interview formats, such as a traditional interview followed by MMI stations or group activities.

Advisor Tip: Review each school's interview format before your interview. Most medical schools describe their interview process on their admissions website or in the interview invitation.

Virtual vs. In-Person Interviews

Medical schools may conduct interviews virtually, in person, or through a combination of both.

Virtual Interviews

Virtual interviews became increasingly common in recent admissions cycles and remain widely used.

Applicants should:

- Test technology in advance.
- Choose a quiet, professional environment.
- Ensure adequate lighting and internet connectivity.
- Maintain eye contact by looking toward the camera.
- Minimize distractions.
- Ensure that the name on the video call application (Zoom, Google Meet, etc.) is professional and appropriate.

In-Person Interviews

In-person interviews allow applicants to experience the campus, meet current students and faculty, and gain a better understanding of the school's culture.

Applicants should:

- Plan travel well in advance.
- Arrive early.
- Dress professionally.
- Budget adequate time for transportation.

Blind vs. Open File Interviews

Medical schools differ in how much information interviewers receive before meeting applicants.

Open File Interviews

Interviewers may review some or all of your application materials beforehand, including:

- Personal statement
- Experiences
- MCAT scores
- GPA
- Letters of recommendation

Questions often build upon information contained within your application.

Blind File Interviews

Interviewers receive little or no information about your academic record or application before the interview.

These interviews focus more heavily on conversation and allow applicants to discuss their experiences without assumptions based on their application.

Some schools use a combination of both interview styles.

What Are Medical School Interviews Evaluating?

Medical school interviews allow admissions committees to evaluate qualities that are difficult to assess on paper, including:

- Communication skills
- Professionalism
- Ethical reasoning
- Self-awareness
- Maturity
- Integrity
- Empathy
- Cultural humility
- Resilience
- Motivation for medicine
- Ability to reflect on experiences

Interviewers are interested in understanding how you think, communicate, and interact with others.

Preparing for Your Interview

Successful interviews begin well before interview day.

Students should:

- Review their application thoroughly.
- Reflect on significant experiences.
- Understand why they want to become a physician.
- Research each school's mission and curriculum.
- Practice discussing their experiences aloud.
- Prepare thoughtful questions for interviewers.

While preparation is important, **applicants should avoid memorizing scripted responses.**

Professionalism and Dress

First impressions matter. Applicants should dress professionally for both virtual and in-person interviews. Business professional attire is generally expected. In-person interviews often include a campus tour, so wear appropriate footwear and plan for the weather.

Throughout the interview day, applicants should demonstrate professionalism by:

- Arriving on time.
- Being respectful to everyone they encounter.
- Communicating thoughtfully.
- Listening carefully.
- Remaining engaged throughout the day.

Remember that professionalism extends beyond the formal interview itself and includes interactions with admissions staff, current students, and other applicants.

Interview Coaching & Mock Interviews

Interviewing is a skill that improves with practice. Health Professions Advising and the [Villanova Career Center](#) offer interview coaching and mock interview opportunities to help students prepare for medical school interviews.

Mock interviews allow applicants to:

- Practice responding to common interview questions.
- Receive individualized feedback.
- Improve confidence and communication.
- Become familiar with different interview formats.

Students are encouraged to schedule interview preparation as soon as they begin receiving interview invitations.

? Frequently Asked Questions: Interviews

What if I don't know the answer to a question?

It is perfectly acceptable to take a moment to think before responding. Interviewers are often more interested in your reasoning and communication than in arriving at a single "correct" answer.

Should I memorize my answers?

No. Preparation is important, but overly rehearsed responses can sound unnatural. Focus on understanding your experiences and reflecting on your motivations rather than memorizing scripts.

Can I bring or take notes?

Policies vary by school. For virtual interviews, applicants may have brief notes available if the interviewers clearly state that notes are allowed, but responses should remain conversational and authentic.

Reading directly from prepared notes on your screen or on paper in front of you is strongly discouraged. **Using AI to generate interview answers in real-time during a virtual interview is unacceptable and, if suspected, may lead to your application being withdrawn or an automatic rejection. It is obvious to the interviewers if you are reading from a script or using AI to answer questions.** Arrive for your interview prepared and genuine, not scripted.

During in-person interviews, notes are generally not used during the interview itself.

Remember: Be prepared, be professional, and **be yourself.**

MCAT and Standardized Testing

Understanding the MCAT

The Medical College Admission Test (MCAT) is a computer-based standardized examination required by nearly all U.S. MD and DO medical schools. Developed by the Association of American Medical Colleges (AAMC), the exam is designed to assess the scientific knowledge, critical reasoning, and problem-solving skills that medical schools have found to be important for success during medical school.

The MCAT consists of the following 4 sections:

1) Biological and Biochemical Foundations of Living Systems

- Biology
- Biochemistry
- Organic chemistry
- Scientific reasoning and experimental design

2) Chemical and Physical Foundations of Biological Systems

- General chemistry
- Organic chemistry
- Physics
- Biology
- Quantitative reasoning and data interpretation

These two science sections emphasize applying foundational concepts to passages, data, experiments, and unfamiliar problems. Students should be comfortable interpreting graphs and tables, analyzing experimental results, evaluating research design, and applying scientific principles to solve novel problems.

3) Psychological, Social, and Biological Foundations of Behavior

- Psychology
- Sociology
- Biology
- Research methods and statistics

This section focuses on the behavioral, psychological, and sociocultural factors that influence health and disease. Questions require students to apply concepts from psychology and sociology while interpreting research findings and data.

4) Critical Analysis and Reasoning Skills (CARS)

- Reading comprehension
- Critical analysis
- Reasoning skills

Unlike the other sections, CARS does not test scientific knowledge. Instead, it evaluates your ability to analyze and interpret complex passages drawn from the humanities and social sciences, including topics such as ethics, philosophy, history, literature, culture, and public policy.

Key Takeaway: The MCAT is more than a test of memorization. Success depends on a strong foundation in the prerequisite sciences, critical thinking, scientific reasoning, data interpretation, and the ability to apply knowledge to unfamiliar situations.

The MCAT in Context

For many students, the MCAT feels like the single most important part of the medical school application. It is an important component of your application, but it is one piece of the mission-aligned selection and retention process. Medical schools evaluate applicants using many factors, including:

- Academic performance
- Clinical experience
- Community service
- Leadership
- Research
- Letters of recommendation
- Personal statement
- Interview performance
- Institutional mission and priorities

The MCAT is one measure of academic readiness and is considered alongside the other components of your application.

Advisor Perspective: Medical schools admit students, not MCAT scores.

When Should I Take the MCAT?

The best time to take the MCAT is when you are academically prepared and consistently performing at or near your goal score on full-length practice exams.

Most students complete the exam after finishing coursework in:

- Biology I & II
- General Chemistry I & II
- Organic Chemistry I & II
- Physics I
- Biochemistry
- Psychology and/or Sociology (strongly recommended)

Because the MCAT tests material from these courses, completing them beforehand generally leads to stronger preparation.

Most applicants take the MCAT before or during the early part of the application year, often in the spring or early summer of junior year for students planning to matriculate immediately after college.

Applicants should also be aware that *many medical schools require MCAT scores earned within approximately two to three years of matriculation, although policies vary by institution*. Always verify individual school requirements.

Advisor Tip: It is almost always better to delay your MCAT until you are truly prepared than to take it prematurely simply to meet a self-imposed timeline.

Preparing for Success

There is no universally "correct" study schedule. Some students prepare over three months, while others spread their studying over six months or longer. Your preparation should reflect your academic background, coursework, work schedule, extracurricular commitments, and learning style.

Successful preparation typically includes:

- A *realistic* study schedule
- Regular content review
- Active practice questions
- Frequent review of mistakes
- Full-length practice examinations in a simulated testing environment
- Time for rest and recovery

Many students attempt to study while simultaneously balancing coursework, research, employment, clinical experiences, leadership, and family responsibilities.

Study Habits Matter More Than Study Hours

Students frequently ask: "How many hours should I study?" There is no magic number. The quality and consistency of your preparation matter more than hitting a particular number of study hours.

Effective study habits include:

- Studying consistently over time rather than cramming
- Reviewing why answers were incorrect
- Revisiting weak content areas
- Mixing content review with practice questions
- Taking regular full-length practice exams
- Simulating actual testing conditions

Sleep, Stress Management, and Self-Care

Preparing for the MCAT can be physically and emotionally demanding. Students often balance the exam with upper-level coursework, internships, clinical experiences, employment, leadership positions, and personal responsibilities. It can be tempting to sacrifice sleep, exercise, hobbies, or time with family and friends in pursuit of additional study hours.

However, research consistently demonstrates that adequate sleep, regular physical activity, stress management, and proper nutrition support learning, memory consolidation, attention, and decision-making, all of which are important during MCAT preparation.

Advisor Perspective: One additional hour of studying at the expense of four hours of sleep is rarely productive. Consistent preparation, healthy routines, and thoughtful recovery often produce better long-term performance than burnout.

Practice Exams & Measuring Readiness

Full-length practice examinations are among the most valuable components of MCAT preparation.

Practice exams help you:

- Build testing endurance
- Identify strengths and weaknesses
- Practice pacing
- Simulate testing conditions
- Monitor progress over time

Look for consistent trends across several full-length practice exams.

A single unusually high, or unusually low, practice score should not determine your testing strategy. Review each practice exam carefully, with particular attention to why you missed each question and what needs to change before the next test.

Understanding MCAT Scores

One of the most common questions students ask is: "What MCAT score do I need?"

Unfortunately, there is no universal answer. Different medical schools have different applicant pools, institutional missions, and admissions priorities. A score that may be highly competitive at one school may be below the average at another. Medical schools evaluate MCAT scores within the broader context of your application.

Factors such as GPA, clinical experience, service, research, leadership, life experiences, institutional mission, and interview performance all contribute to admissions decisions. For this reason, **applicants should avoid comparing themselves to arbitrary score thresholds or internet discussions that lack context.**

Resources such as the [Medical School Admission Requirements \(MSAR\)](#) and the [Choose DO Explorer](#) provide school-specific admissions data that can help applicants develop realistic school lists.

Minimum MCAT Scores

Some medical schools publish minimum MCAT scores, or minimum subsection scores, that applicants must meet before their applications will be reviewed.

These minimums vary by institution and may include:

- Minimum overall MCAT score
- Minimum subsection score
- Maximum age of an MCAT score (e.g., scores earned within the past two or three years)

Meeting a published minimum generally means that an application can proceed through the school's initial screening process; competitive scores may be considerably higher.

Likewise, an applicant whose score falls below a published minimum may not receive further consideration, regardless of strengths elsewhere in the application.

Advisor Perspective: Use published minimums as one piece of your school-selection process. Consider your full academic profile and consult school-specific admissions data to identify programs where your application is likely to be competitive.

Test Day Tips

The weeks leading up to your exam are just as important as the months of preparation.

As test day approaches:

- Maintain a consistent sleep schedule.
- Avoid making major changes to your study routine.
- Continue taking full-length practice exams under realistic conditions.
- Confirm your testing center, required identification, and exam-day logistics.
- Prepare meals, snacks, and transportation in advance.
- Avoid comparing your preparation to that of others.

On test day:

- Eat a nutritious meal.
- Arrive early.
- Use scheduled breaks to hydrate, eat, and reset mentally.
- If one section feels difficult, avoid dwelling on it during subsequent sections.

Remember that *many students leave the MCAT feeling uncertain about their performance*. Feeling challenged after the exam is common and does not reliably predict your final score.

Retaking the MCAT

Deciding whether to retake the MCAT is one of the most common questions applicants face, and the answer is highly individualized.

A retake may be appropriate if:

- Your official score is substantially lower than your consistent practice exam performance.
- Significant personal circumstances affected your performance.
- Your score is unlikely to support your intended school list.
- You have identified weaknesses in your preparation and have developed a new strategy.

Before registering for another exam, ask yourself:

- Have I changed my study approach?
- Can I realistically dedicate the time needed to improve?
- Am I consistently earning higher scores on multiple recent full-length practice exams?
- Will a higher score meaningfully strengthen my application?
- Have I discussed this approach with my HPA Advisor?

Medical schools receive all MCAT scores, even expired scores. Many schools appreciate meaningful improvement over time. However, multiple attempts with little or no improvement, or a lower subsequent score, may not strengthen an application.

Advisor Perspective: *Retake the MCAT because your preparation suggests you are likely to improve, not because you hope to improve. Practice exam trends should guide your decision more than optimism alone.*

Additional Standardized Assessments

Some medical schools require additional assessments designed to evaluate professional competencies beyond academic knowledge. Requirements vary by institution. Applicants should always review each school's admissions website to determine which additional assessments are required, if any.

CASPer

CASPer is an online situational judgment test administered by Acuity Insights.

CASPer evaluates professional and interpersonal competencies such as:

- Communication
- Professionalism
- Ethics
- Collaboration
- Empathy
- Problem-solving

Applicants respond to written and video-based scenarios involving realistic interpersonal and ethical situations.

Preparing for CASPer

Preparation should focus on:

- Becoming familiar with the testing format
- Completing official practice scenarios
- Practicing clear, organized written responses
- Reflecting on ethical decision-making and professionalism

Most applicants complete CASPer during the application cycle after submitting their primary application, though timing should be based on individual school requirements.

Duet

Duet, also administered by Acuity Insights, is a values-based assessment used by a limited number of medical schools.

Duet compares an applicant's preferences for an educational environment with characteristics identified by participating schools.

There are no right or wrong answers, and applicants do not receive a traditional score.

PREview

The AAMC PREview Professional Readiness Exam is a situational judgment assessment used by a growing number of medical schools. Depending on the school, PREview may be required, recommended, or accepted to satisfy a situational judgment test requirement.

PREview evaluates professional readiness across two broad skill areas:

Personal Accountability

- Commitment to Learning & Growth
- Reliability & Dependability
- Resilience & Adaptability
- Ethical Responsibility to Self and Others

Relational Skills

- Teamwork & Collaboration
- Interpersonal Skills
- Empathy & Compassion
- Self-Awareness
- Understanding Others

Preparation focuses on reviewing the official competency framework and completing AAMC practice materials.

? Frequently Asked Questions: MCAT and Standardized Testing

Should I take a commercial prep course?

Commercial prep courses are helpful for some students but are not required for success. Consider your learning style, budget, and need for structure when deciding whether a course is appropriate.

Can I self-study?

Yes. Many students successfully prepare using official AAMC resources and reputable third-party materials. Self-study requires discipline, organization, and a realistic study schedule.

Can I submit my application before receiving my MCAT score?

Yes. Applicants may submit their primary application before receiving their MCAT score. However, medical schools generally will not make admissions decisions until an official score has been received. Additionally, *applicants should discuss this strategy with their HPA Advisor prior to submitting applications without a valid MCAT score.*

Helpful Resources: MCAT and Standardized Testing

- [AAMC MCAT Preparation Resources](#)
- [MCAT Essentials for Testing 2026](#)
- [Medical School Admission Requirements \(MSAR\)](#)
- [AAMC PREview Preparation Resources](#)
- Acuity Insights [CASPer](#)
- Acuity Insights [Duet](#)
- [Choose DO Explorer](#)
- [AAMC Fee Assistance Program](#)
- Health Professions Advising – [Make an Appointment](#)

MCAT Study Resources

- [Khan Academy MCAT Collection](#)
- [Jack Westin](#)
- [UWorld MCAT](#)
- [Blueprint MCAT](#)
- [Kaplan MCAT](#)
- [Princeton Review MCAT](#)
- [AnKing MCAT Deck \(Anki\)](#)

Study Planning

- [AAMC MCAT Study Planning](#)

Health & Wellness

- [Health and Well-Being at Villanova](#)
- [AAMC FIRST Program](#)

Before Purchasing an MCAT Prep Course

Many students wonder whether they need to spend thousands of dollars on a commercial MCAT preparation course.

The answer depends on your learning style, study habits, budget, and need for structure. Some students benefit from the accountability of a formal course, while others are highly successful using official AAMC materials and free or lower-cost resources.

Before investing in a commercial prep program, consider [meeting with Health Professions Advising](#) to discuss your study plan and determine which resources may best support your individual learning needs.

Selecting Medical Schools

Developing a thoughtful school list is one of the most important, and often overlooked, parts of the medical school application process.

A well-balanced school list should reflect your academic profile, experiences, professional goals, personal preferences, and each institution's mission.

Students often ask, ‘Where should I apply?’ A strong school list will look different for every applicant and should reflect your qualifications, interests, and career goals.

Factors to Consider When Building a School List

Mission Fit

Every medical school has its own mission and educational priorities. Some schools place a strong emphasis on:

- Primary care
- Rural or underserved medicine
- Community engagement
- Research
- Urban health
- Global health
- Public health
- Diversity and inclusion
- Academic medicine

Applicants should carefully review each school's mission statement and consider whether their experiences and interests align with the institution's priorities.

Advisor Tip: Mission fit is often just as important as academic metrics.

Academic Competitiveness

Use your academic metrics as one factor when developing your school list. Consider:

- Overall GPA
- Science GPA
- MCAT
- Academic trends
- Prerequisite coursework

School-specific admissions data available through [MSAR](#) and [Choose DO Explorer](#) can help applicants better understand how their academic profile compares with recently admitted students.

Remember that medical schools evaluate applicants using [mission-aligned selection and retention](#). Strong experiences, leadership, research, service, and compelling personal qualities may strengthen an application beyond academic metrics alone. Likewise, exceptional academic metrics do not guarantee admission.

Research vs. Clinical Focus

Medical schools differ considerably in their educational emphasis. Some institutions are nationally recognized for:

- Biomedical research
- Physician-scientist training
- Academic medicine
- NIH-funded research

Others place greater emphasis on:

- Clinical education
- Community-based medicine
- Primary care
- Service-learning
- Early patient exposure

Students interested in research-intensive careers may wish to prioritize institutions with extensive research opportunities, while applicants primarily interested in clinical practice may find that other schools better align with their goals.

Geographic Preferences

Location can significantly influence your medical school experience.

Consider factors such as:

- Distance from family and support systems
- Climate
- Cost of living
- Access to transportation
- Opportunities for spouses or partners
- Residency preferences
- Regional practice interests

Applicants should also be aware that many *public* medical schools give preference to in-state residents or applicants with strong ties to the state.

Cost

The financial investment associated with medical school extends beyond tuition. Applicants should consider:

- Tuition
- Fees
- Cost of living
- Financial aid opportunities
- Scholarship availability
- Travel expenses
- Interview costs (when applicable)

Medical school represents a significant financial commitment, and cost should be considered alongside educational fit.

Applying Broadly

Medical school admissions are highly competitive.

Most successful applicants apply to multiple schools rather than relying on only a few highly selective institutions. A balanced school list should include institutions where your academic profile, experiences, and interests align well with each school's mission and admissions priorities.

Organizing Your School List

Applying to medical school requires managing a large amount of information. Many applicants find it helpful to maintain a spreadsheet or planning document to track important information throughout the application cycle.

Suggested columns include:

- School Name
- Degree
- State
- Mission/Focus
- GPA/MCAT Data
- Prerequisites
- CASPer/PREview Required
- Secondary Received

- Secondary Submitted
- Interview
- Decision
- Notes

Additional columns may include:

- Application fees
- Secondary fees
- Letters of recommendation requirements
- Tuition
- Residency preference
- Curriculum type
- Research opportunities
- Personal impressions
- Deadline dates

Staying organized throughout the application cycle can reduce stress and help ensure that important deadlines are not missed.

Balancing Opportunity and Cost

Applying to more schools may create additional opportunities, but it also increases the financial and logistical demands of the application process. Consider application and secondary fees, testing expenses, and potential interview costs when deciding how broad your school list should be.

Build a thoughtful school list that balances competitiveness, mission fit, and financial considerations.

Health Professions Advising can help students identify an application strategy that is both realistic and financially manageable.

Meet with Health Professions Advising

Developing an appropriate school list is one of the most valuable services provided by Health Professions Advising.

Students are strongly encouraged to meet with an advisor to discuss:

- Academic competitiveness
- Prerequisites
- School selection strategy
- Mission fit
- Geographic preferences
- Gap year plans
- Application timing
- Individual school requirements

School lists should be individualized using each applicant's academic profile, experiences, goals, preferences, and school-specific admissions information.

? Frequently Asked Questions: Selecting Medical Schools

How many schools should I apply to?

There is no universally recommended number of schools. The appropriate number depends on many factors, including your academic profile, state residency, career goals, competitiveness, and financial considerations.

Should I apply to both MD and DO schools?

Many applicants choose to apply to both MD and DO programs. Whether this is appropriate depends on your academic profile, career goals, and school selection strategy. Health Professions Advising can help you determine the best approach for your individual circumstances.

How often should I update my school list?

Your school list should remain flexible throughout the application cycle. New MCAT scores, evolving interests, additional experiences, or changes in application timing may influence your strategy.

Advisor Perspective: Rankings are only one piece of the puzzle. While national rankings may provide information about research funding or reputation, they rarely capture the factors that matter most to your medical school experience, such as institutional culture, student support, clinical opportunities, curriculum, advising, geographic fit, and overall well-being. A medical school where you feel supported and aligned with the mission is often a better choice than one selected primarily for its ranking.

Gap Years and Reapplying

Students apply to medical school on many different timelines, and matriculating immediately after college is only one option.

Many successful applicants take one or more gap years before matriculating. In recent years, the average age of entering medical students has gradually increased, reflecting a growing number of applicants who choose to strengthen their applications, gain additional experiences, pursue graduate education, conduct research, serve their communities, or simply take additional time to prepare before applying.

Taking a Gap Year

A gap year is a period between completing your undergraduate education and beginning medical school. Depending on your goals, you may take one or more gap years before applying or before matriculating.

Gap years are increasingly common and can give students additional time to strengthen their applications and continue growing personally and professionally.

Why Take a Gap Year?

Students choose to take gap years for many different reasons, including:

- Strengthening academic preparation
- Completing prerequisite coursework
- Improving an MCAT score
- Gaining additional clinical experience
- Participating in research
- Expanding community service or leadership experiences
- Working in healthcare or another professional setting
- Pursuing graduate education
- Saving money before medical school
- Focusing on personal well-being or family responsibilities

A productive gap year should be intentional and aligned with your individual goals.

Using a Gap Year Effectively

Medical schools generally view gap years positively when applicants use them to continue developing as future physicians.

Examples of meaningful gap year activities include:

- Working as a medical assistant, scribe, EMT, CNA, or research coordinator

- Conducting full-time research
- Participating in service programs such as AmeriCorps
- Pursuing a master's or post-baccalaureate program
- Expanding volunteer leadership
- Continuing long-term community engagement
- Working in another profession while maintaining meaningful clinical and service involvement

Admissions committees are often interested in how you used your time, what you learned, and how those experiences contributed to your personal and professional growth.

Academic Enhancement

For some students, additional academic preparation after graduation may be beneficial before applying to medical school. Academic enhancement can strengthen an application by demonstrating improved academic performance, reinforcing foundational science knowledge, or completing prerequisite coursework. It is not necessary, or appropriate, for every applicant. Whether academic enhancement is recommended depends on your individual academic record, MCAT performance, and the expectations of the medical schools to which you plan to apply.

Two common pathways for academic enhancement are post-baccalaureate (post-bacc) programs and Specialized Master's Programs (SMPs).

Program Type	Purpose
Post-Baccalaureate Program	Designed for students who need to complete prerequisite coursework, improve their undergraduate GPA, or demonstrate stronger academic performance through additional undergraduate-level science courses.
Specialized Master's Program (SMP)	Graduate-level programs that provide advanced biomedical science coursework similar to the first year of professional school. These programs are generally intended for applicants who have completed the prerequisites but need to demonstrate their ability to succeed in a rigorous graduate-level curriculum.

Academic enhancement is only one way to strengthen an application. Depending on your individual circumstances, improving your MCAT score, gaining additional clinical or shadowing experiences, expanding your service involvement, or delaying your application to continue developing professionally may be more appropriate than pursuing additional coursework.

Post-baccalaureate programs and SMPs require a significant investment of time and money. Additional coursework is most useful when it addresses a specific academic need; enrolling in a program does not automatically make an applicant more competitive.

HPA Tip: Before pursuing a post-baccalaureate program, SMP, or other form of academic enhancement, meet with your Health Professions Advisor. Together, you can evaluate your academic record, discuss your career goals, and determine whether academic enhancement, or another strategy, is the most effective way to strengthen your application.

Reapplying to Medical School

Receiving an unsuccessful admissions outcome can be disappointing, but it does not mean that medical school is no longer within reach. Many applicants are admitted after strengthening their applications and reapplying.

The most successful reapplicants approach a second application cycle with honesty, reflection, and a willingness to grow.

What Do Medical Schools Want to See in a Reapplicant?

Medical schools generally expect reapplicants to demonstrate meaningful improvement since their previous application.

Depending on the circumstances, this may include:

- Additional clinical experience
- More community service
- Continued research
- Leadership development
- Improved academic performance
- A stronger MCAT score
- More thoughtful school selection
- A stronger personal statement
- Improved interview preparation
- A new or updated letter of recommendation from activities during gap year

Simply submitting the same application a second time without meaningful changes is unlikely to improve the outcome.

Admissions committees want to understand what you learned from the previous cycle and how you have continued to grow.

Reapplying: Separating Myth from Reality

Myth: "Medical schools will think less of me because I didn't get in the first time."

Reality: Reapplying is common, and many successful medical students are reapplicants. According to the AAMC, ~25% of all medical school applicants each year are reapplicants. Admissions committees do not automatically view reapplicants negatively; instead, they evaluate whether your application has meaningfully improved since your previous cycle. A reapplication that demonstrates growth, reflection, and stronger preparation can be very competitive.

Myth: "If I reapply to the same medical school, they won't even look at my application."

Reality: Many applicants are accepted by schools that previously rejected them. Reapplying to the same schools is appropriate if you have strengthened your application and remain a good fit for their mission. Admissions committees will review your updated application and evaluate the progress you have made since your previous submission.

Myth: "I have to completely reinvent my application before I reapply."

Reality: Admissions committees are looking for meaningful growth. You do not need to become an entirely different applicant before reapplying. Strengthening one or two important areas, such as improving your MCAT score, sharpening your interviewing skills, gaining additional clinical experience, expanding community service, or strengthening your school list, may be far more valuable than trying to overhaul every aspect of your application.

Myth: "If I wasn't accepted, I should apply again as soon as possible."

Reality: Reapplying before addressing the weaknesses in your previous application often leads to the same result. It is generally better to take additional time to strengthen your academic record, experiences, school list, or application materials than to rush into another application cycle before you are ready.

Applicants must answer all application questions honestly and review each school's specific policies.

Reflect Before Reapplying

Before beginning another application cycle, consider:

- What were the strengths of my previous application?
- Where could I realistically improve?
- Have I gained meaningful new experiences?
- Is my school list appropriate?
- Has my motivation for medicine become clearer?

- Am I submitting a substantially stronger application than last year?

Sometimes the most strategic decision is to wait another year if doing so will allow you to make significant improvements.

Meet with Health Professions Advising

Whether you are considering a gap year or preparing to reapply, Health Professions Advising can help you develop an individualized plan.

Together, we can:

- Review your previous application
- Identify strengths and opportunities for growth
- Discuss school list strategy
- Evaluate MCAT performance
- Recommend additional experiences
- Develop a realistic application timeline

Thoughtful planning can make a significant difference when using a gap year or preparing to reapply.

? Frequently Asked Questions: Gap Years and Reapplying

Will taking a gap year hurt my chances of getting into medical school?

No. Gap years are increasingly common, and many medical schools view them favorably when applicants use the time to gain meaningful experiences, strengthen their application, and continue developing personally and professionally. What you do with your gap year and how you frame it in your application/interview is far more important than the passing of time itself.

Should I apply now or wait another year?

That depends on your individual circumstances. If another year would allow you to substantially strengthen your application, waiting may be the more strategic choice. Discuss your situation with Health Professions Advising before making this decision.

Will reapplying hurt my chances?

Not necessarily. Many successful applicants are admitted after reapplying. What matters most is whether your new application demonstrates meaningful growth, reflection, and improvement since your previous cycle.

In Conclusion

Pursuing a career in medicine requires curiosity, perseverance, resilience, and a lifelong commitment to learning and serving others.

Successful applicants follow many different timelines. Strong preparation includes a solid academic foundation, meaningful experiences, professional growth, thoughtful reflection, and an application submitted when you are ready.

Health Professions Advising is committed to partnering with you throughout that process. Whether you are exploring medicine for the first time, planning for medical school prerequisites, preparing for the MCAT, building a school list, navigating the application process, or considering a gap year, we are here to provide guidance, encouragement, and individualized support.

We encourage you to meet with us regularly throughout your undergraduate career, including well before you are ready to apply. The earlier we begin working together, the more intentional we can be in helping you identify opportunities, develop your experiences, and build a competitive application that reflects your unique strengths and aspirations.

Through thoughtful planning, honest feedback, and collaborative advising, we will work with you to develop an application strategy that aligns with your goals and supports your long-term success.

Most importantly, we hope this handbook helps you prepare for both medical school admission and the responsibilities of becoming a compassionate, ethical, and capable physician.

We look forward to working with you and wish you every success on your journey to medicine.

Best wishes for continued success,

The Villanova University Health Professions Advising Program